# Gayane Baghumyan

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## Research Interests

Behavioral and Experimental Economics; Discrimination, Identity, Motivated Reasoning

## References

**Michal Bauer** (Advisor)
Professor of Economics
CERGE-EI
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**John List**
Griffin Distinguished Service Professor of Economics
University of Chicago
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**Andreas Ortmann**
Professor of Experimental and Behavioral Economics
UNSW Business School
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## Education

**Ph.D. in Economics**, CERGE-EI, Prague *Exp. defense: Fall 2026*

Awarded as joint U.S. and Czech doctoral degrees.
Dissertation: *Essays in Experimental Economics*.

Research stay at the University of Chicago: joined John List's group, Sept 2023 – Mar 2024.
Research stay at Princeton University, Oct 2023

**M.A. in Economics and Econometrics**, CERGE-EI, Prague (U.S. degree) *2020*
**M.A. in Economics**, Armenian State University of Economics (ASUE), *summa cum laude* *2018*
**B.A. in Economics**, Armenian State University of Economics (ASUE), *summa cum laude* *2016*

## Job Market Paper

**Can Plausible Errors Provide Cover for Racial Discrimination?** Latest version

**Abstract:** In this study, I ask whether ambiguity in a decision environment can provide moral cover for racial discrimination. The study is motivated by the idea that discriminatory preferences may not be expressed when people cannot easily justify acting on them. Ambiguity can provide a plausible non-discriminatory reason for biased behavior. I conducted a preregistered, incentivized experiment with 4,327 White U.S. participants who allocated real monetary bonuses to actual recipients. The experiment varied whether the ambiguously described payoff option benefited a Black recipient or a White recipient. This design enables me to distinguish between a general tendency to avoid ambiguously framed options and the selective use of ambiguity as a justification for discrimination. The results do not support the hypothesis that ambiguity provides moral cover for discrimination in the full experimental sample. Participants choose the ambiguously framed option more often when it benefits the Black recipient than when it benefits the White recipient,

the opposite of what the selective use of ambiguity against Black recipients would predict. Overall, the evidence is more consistent with a general tendency to avoid ambiguously framed options than with ambiguity serving as moral cover for racial discrimination.

## Working Papers

**Sexual-Orientation Discrimination and Biological Attributions: Experimental Evidence from Russia**

Pre-registered online experiment with Russian adults, using incentivized allocation tasks. The sample was quota-matched by age and gender. Attribution theory predicts that presenting sexual orientation as innate should reduce discrimination. Contrary to the pre-registered hypothesis, exposure to scientific evidence for biological explanations of homosexuality *increased* discriminatory behavior. In intolerant contexts, information provision may exacerbate the behavior it is intended to reduce.

**Religious Identity and Sexual-Orientation Discrimination: Experimental Evidence from Russia**

Randomized online experiment ($n = 2{,}093$) varying whether participants answer religion-related questions before or after incentivized allocation decisions and LGB-related policy questions. Participants allocate significantly less to same-sex than to different-sex profiles, and more religious respondents report less policy support. The religious prime itself has no statistically robust average effect. The paper adds causal evidence to a literature that has relied largely on correlations, and delimits what this class of priming intervention can achieve.

## Teaching

Teaching Assistant, Experimental Economics, Graduate (Ph.D. level), CERGE-EI *2023-2024*

Experimental design and Qualtrics, including JavaScript integration. Avg. Evaluation: 4.75/5

Instructor, Applied Statistics, Statistics, Armenia. ASUE, Armenia *2022-2024*

Mentored 50+ students in applied statistics and experimental research. Avg. Evaluation: 4.79/5

## Experience

**Data Scientist**, Absa Technology, Prague *May 2026 – present*

Observational causal inference and experimentation

Data Analyst, Absa Technology, Prague *Sept 2024 – May 2026*

Doctoral Researcher/ PhD candidate, CERGE-EI, Prague *Sept 2023 – Dec 2025*

Research Assistant, CERGE-EI, Prague *Sept 2019 – Dec 2023*

Student Assistant, University of Zurich, Remote *Feb 2019 – May 2019*

## Conferences & Talks

Armenian Economic Association (AEA) 2026, Yerevan; AEA 2024, Yerevan; Behavioral Economics Lab Group, Chicago Booth, 2024; University of Alabama Brown Bag (invited); UChicago Economics Brown Bag, 2023; AFE 2023, UChicago; EEA-ESEM 2023, Barcelona; ESA 2023, Lyon; AEA 2023, Yerevan; IAREP-SABE 47th, Nice; IMEBESS 2023, Lisbon; RES & SES 2023, Glasgow; AEA CSQIEP, virtual; ESA 2022, Bologna; SEA 2022, Bratislava; AEA 2022, Yerevan; Teaching Economics, CERGE-EI; oTree course, UJEP; MCC Dialogues 2020, Budapest.

## Grants, Fellowships and Awards

Charles University Grant Agency (GA UK) — **Principal Investigator**: ≈ EUR 33,000 *2021–2023*

Young Economist of the Czech Republic: 3rd Prize *2024*

Stapleton Scholar, CERGE-EI *2023*

GEOCEP Research Stay, University of Chicago *2023*

ASUE Top Student Scholarship *2014–2015*

## Professional Service

Referee: American Economic Review, Journal of Political Economy, Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics, Experimental Economics

## Skills

**Software:** Python, Stata, SQL; Qualtrics, Databricks, Git, Latex

**Methods:** Experimental design, causal inference, applied econometrics, survey methodology

**Field and lab experiments:** End-to-end study management: design and piloting, participant recruitment, IRB protocols, data cleaning and analysis.

## Languages

Armenian (native); English and Russian (fluent); Czech (basic).